When I come home, I'm in quite extreme distress. I have a scan and it reveals that I have a severe stress fracture, and I have been playing with it throughout the tour, incessantly damaging it each time I ran in to bowl. The worst thing for a stress fracture, the doctor tells me, is high-impact activities, like, let's say, bowling fast, for example. I am put in a plastic corset for six weeks, where I do not leave the house. I am either lying still or walking very upright, maddening myself, thinking about all the hours I am missing, all the players I am now behind in the pecking order for England in the height of their success. The only time I am not wearing the corset is in bed. The same way I have learned that simple dedicated repetition can take you up and out of your situation and propel you to places you couldn't imagine, I learn that the same is possible the other way. With nothing to focus on and no way to exorcise the feeling, I allow myself to slip into a spiral of doom. I'm not playing great for England anyway, I begin to say to myself, so why should I do it at all any more? Maybe I should find something else I can do, something that I'm actually good at. Cricket's not where I belong. I start to fixate on the last year, of carrying the drinks, feeling surplus to requirements, being on the outside of conversations and groups – of feeling alone.

Daniella is with me every day. She listens to me telling her that I don't want to play cricket any more. She nods along at first, telling me how sorry she is. It's like she notices the way a mind can loop a thought around the brain, and she can see me distorting what has come before and what will come after. One day, when it has its grips on me, the same loneliness of the wishing to be someone else, but now armed and teethed with mental self-flagellation, she tells me to stop it. 'The world so rarely gives people a thing they are born to do,' she says. 'And you have it, and you are going to do it again better than you ever have.' Inside the moment, I come to think of it as a pre-ordained challenge, that in some way I was meant to meet Daniella when I did, that I could help her with her pain and, in turn, she is now helping me with mine. Her life comes with a perspective now weighted with the tragedy of her brother. He had a life in front of him, a talent for a sport, and he didn't have the chance to feel it open his life up and take him to other places. It is important to her – then on a sub-conscious level – not to see it happen to someone else that she is close to again. 'Look, believe in